

UNLIKE THE MAHAYUTI, THE MVA DOES NOT HAVE THE STRENGTH OF LEADERSHIP TO ENSURE THE BELLIGERENTS FALL IN LINE

manabad) against Omraje Nimbalkar of the Sena (UBT). Still, asked if she would make an effort to expand the Ajit faction's footprint, she responded with an ambiguous line: "Why would I do that? My husband is a BJP MLA." Rana Jagjitsinh, incidentally, is the son of former NCP minister Dr Padamsinh Patil and Sunetra Pawar's nephew. Local Sena functionaries are upset with the NCP cornering the seat—health minister Tanaji Sawant was eager to fight from Osmanabad. Subterranean rumblings within the Mahayuti have also been heard in constituencies like Maval, where local BJP and NCP leaders are ranged against Shinde Sena MP Shrirang Barne, who has the Sena (UBT)'s Sanjog Waghere Patil taking him on.

And though Maharashtra Navnirman Sena (MNS) president Raj Thackeray has announced "unconditional support" to make Modi prime minister for a third term, this has created the perception that the BJP is clutching at straws. Raj has consistently changed his electoral positions and today his party is a pale shadow of its former self.

Meanwhile, Shinde Sena leader and former minister Suresh Navale has attacked the BJP for using surveys as a pretext to drop candidates it did not like. "Surveys are not credible beyond a point," says another Shinde Sena minister. "The mood changes as polling day draws close. The BJP is trying to play it safe as they are on the back foot in Maharashtra, which accounts for the second-highest seats (48) after UP (80)." Unhappy with the BJP staking a claim on undivided Sena's traditional seats like Nashik and Ratnagiri-Sindhudurg, the minister says this "sent a wrong message to the masses since the Sena's name evokes an emotional connect".

Shinde's men are also upset at the Ajit faction getting greater preference over them in the Mahayuti. But, as a senior Ajit-NCP minister notes, that is because the BJP felt the Shinde Sena would be unable to deliver the goods in the Lok Sabha election. "Many of the 40 MLAs who went with Shinde were elected due to the Modi wave. In contrast, we were elected despite this wave and because we have a strong connect in our constituencies apart from control over cooperative institutions like banks, milk federations and sugar mills," he says. Another factional source says they have been better negotiators.

While admitting that disagreements over seat-sharing are part of every alliance, a source from the Mahayuti camp says the BJP has managed to have its way as it was the bigger party, had not seen a vertical split like the Sena and NCP and had the data and the perspective. "Their approach to elections is more scientific," he says. "In the absence of a Modi wave and dominance of local issues, the candidate matters."

A senior BJP leader points to how it is necessary for the party to strike a balance in its power equations in the Mahayuti and the resultant optics. "We are certainly the big brother in this alliance... but the perception that the Shinde Sena is our feudatory is not convenient in Maharashtra since it goes against regional sentiment," he says.

Shinde Sena spokesperson Sheetal Mhatre denies there is any disgruntlement. "The common agenda is to make Modiji the prime minister. In contrast, our opponents have individual agendas and lack a prime ministerial face," she says. Maharashtra BJP chief spokesperson Keshav Upadhye, too, denies claims that the party is acting like the big brother, saying the BJP did not decide on the other constituents' candidates, their respective leaderships did, and that it would work hard to elect them.

Political analyst Abhay Deshpande says the BJP is being guided by the belief that it will have a better strike rate than its two breakaway allies and is hence trying to contest as many seats as it can. "The BJP feels its two allies will have to bear the brunt of anti-incumbency. Their presence can also not impede the BJP's goal of 'Shatpratishat BJP' (100 per cent BJP)," he says.

Do the rumblings in the Mahayuti mean it's advantage Maha Vikas Aghadi (MVA)? A senior Congress leader does not think so. Rumblings can be heard in both alliances, he says. However, by dint of being in the Opposition, the MVA does not have the privilege of ensuring that the belligerents fall in line. In contrast, the BJP can ensure dissenters fall in line because, as he pithily says, "In the ruling alliance, *sabka malik ek hai*." Truer words were never spoken. ■